

Psalms 89

The Everlasting Covenant

Mercy shall be built up for ever... I will make known thy faithfulness

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *I will sing of the mercies of the LORD for ever: with my mouth will I make known thy faithfulness to all generations.*
- 2 *For I have said, Mercy shall be built up for ever: thy faithfulness shalt thou establish in the very heavens.*
- 3 *I have made a covenant with my chosen, I have sworn unto David my servant,*
- 4 *Thy seed will I establish for ever, and build up thy throne to all generations. Selah.*
- 5 *And the heavens shall praise thy wonders, O LORD: thy faithfulness also in the congregation of the saints.*
- 6 *For who in the heaven can be compared unto the LORD? who among the sons of the mighty can be likened unto the LORD?*
- 7 *God is greatly to be feared in the assembly of the saints, and to be had in reverence of all them that are about him.*
- 8 *O LORD God of hosts, who is a strong LORD like unto thee? or to thy faithfulness round about thee?*
- 9 *Thou rulest the raging of the sea: when the waves thereof arise, thou stillest them.*
- 10 *Thou hast broken Rahab in pieces, as one that is slain; thou hast scattered thine enemies with thy strong arm.*
- 11 *The heavens are thine, the earth also is thine: as for the world and the fulness thereof, thou hast founded them.*
- 12 *The north and the south thou hast created them: Tabor and Hermon shall rejoice in thy name.*
- 13 *Thou hast a mighty arm: strong is thy hand, and high is thy right hand.*
- 14 *Justice and judgment are the habitation of thy throne: mercy and truth shall go before thy face.*
- 15 *Blessed is the people that know the joyful sound: they shall walk, O LORD, in the light of thy countenance.*
- 16 *In thy name shall they rejoice all the day: and in thy righteousness shall they be exalted.*
- 17 *For thou art the glory of their strength: and in thy favour our horn shall be exalted.*
- 18 *For the LORD is our defence; and the Holy One of Israel is our king.*
- 19 *Then thou spakest in vision to thy holy one, and saidst, I have laid help upon one that is mighty; I have exalted one chosen out of the people.*
- 20 *I have found David my servant; with my holy oil have I anointed him:*
- 21 *With whom my hand shall be established: mine arm also shall strengthen him.*
- 22 *The enemy shall not exact upon him; nor the son of wickedness afflict him.*
- 23 *And I will beat down his foes before his face, and plague them that hate him.*
- 24 *But my faithfulness and my mercy shall be with him: and in my name shall his horn be exalted.*
- 25 *I will set his hand also in the sea, and his right hand in the rivers.*
- 26 *He shall cry unto me, Thou art my father, my God, and the rock of my salvation.*
- 27 *Also I will make him my firstborn, higher than the kings of the earth.*
- 28 *My mercy will I keep for him for evermore, and my covenant shall stand fast with him.*
- 29 *His seed also will I make to endure for ever, and his throne as the days of heaven.*
- 30 *If his children forsake my law, and walk not in my judgments;*
- 31 *If they break my statutes, and keep not my commandments;*
- 32 *Then will I visit their transgression with the rod, and their iniquity with stripes.*
- 33 *Nevertheless my lovingkindness will I not utterly take from him, nor suffer my faithfulness to fail.*
- 34 *My covenant will I not break, nor alter the thing that is gone out of my lips.*
- 35 *Once have I sworn by my holiness that I will not lie unto David.*
- 36 *His seed shall endure for ever, and his throne as the sun before me.*
- 37 *It shall be established for ever as the moon, and as a faithful witness in heaven. Selah.*
- 38 *But thou hast cast off and abhorred, thou hast been wroth with thine anointed.*
- 39 *Thou hast made void the covenant of thy servant: thou hast profaned his crown by casting it to the ground.*
- 40 *Thou hast broken down all his hedges; thou hast brought his strong holds to ruin.*
- 41 *All that pass by the way spoil him: he is a reproach to his neighbours.*

42 *Thou hast set up the right hand of his adversaries; thou hast made all his enemies to rejoice.*
 43 *Thou hast also turned the edge of his sword, and hast not made him to stand in the battle.*
 44 *Thou hast made his glory to cease, and cast his throne down to the ground.*
 45 *The days of his youth hast thou shortened: thou hast covered him with shame. Selah.*
 46 *How long, LORD? wilt thou hide thyself for ever? shall thy wrath burn like fire?*
 47 *Remember how short my time is: wherefore hast thou made all men in vain?*
 48 *What man is he that liveth, and shall not see death? shall he deliver his soul from the hand of the grave? Selah.*
 49 *Lord, where are thy former lovingkindnesses, which thou swarest unto David in thy truth?*
 50 *Remember, Lord, the reproach of thy servants; how I do bear in my bosom the reproach of all the mighty people;*
 51 *Wherewith thine enemies have reproached, O LORD; wherewith they have reproached the footsteps of thine anointed.*
 52 *Blessed be the LORD for evermore. Amen, and Amen.*

2 · CONTEXT

A long psalm of Ethan the Ezrahite that begins in confident celebration of God's covenant with David—an everlasting throne, an unbreakable promise—before turning abruptly, in its final third, to raw complaint that this very covenant now appears broken, the anointed king cast down and disgraced. The tension is left largely unresolved within the psalm itself. Henry reads it as an honest wrestling with the apparent gap between God's sworn promises and present, painful reality; the New Testament ultimately resolves this tension in Christ, the true and lasting Son of David.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-4

The psalm opens with a vow to sing of God's mercies forever and make His faithfulness known to every generation, grounding this in the specific covenant God made with David: 'I will establish your seed forever, and build your throne to all generations.'

Verse 5-8

Praise widens to cosmic scale: the heavens themselves praise God's wonders, and among the assembly of holy ones none compares to Him. He is described as greatly to be feared and revered above all, a God of unmatched strength and faithfulness.

Verse 9-14

God's sovereign power over creation is celebrated—stilling the raging sea, breaking Rahab (a symbol of chaos) in pieces, founding heaven and earth, creating north and south, with Tabor and Hermon rejoicing in His name. His throne rests specifically on justice and righteousness, with mercy and truth going before His face.

Verse 15-18

Blessing belongs to those who know the joyful sound of true worship, who walk in the light of God's presence, rejoicing in His name all day, exalted through His righteousness. God Himself is called their shield and glory, their king the Holy One of Israel.

Verse 19-24

The Davidic covenant is recounted directly in God's own speech: a chosen one found among the people, anointed with holy oil, established and strengthened, protected from enemies and oppressors, with God's own faithfulness and mercy accompanying him and his horn exalted in God's name.

Verse 25-29

The covenant's scope expands: dominion over sea and rivers, a unique father-son relationship with God, elevation above all earthly kings, mercy kept forever, and—critically—the promise that his seed and throne will endure as long as the heavens themselves.

Verse 30-34

A conditional clause is introduced: if his descendants forsake God's law and break His statutes, they will be punished with the rod for their transgression. Yet, crucially, God's mercy will not be utterly withdrawn, nor will His covenant faithfulness be allowed to fail—discipline, not abandonment, is the promised response to unfaithfulness.

Verse 35-37

God's oath is restated in the strongest possible terms: sworn once by His own holiness, He will not lie to David; his seed will endure forever, his throne established like the sun and moon, a faithful witness in heaven itself.

Verse 38-45

An abrupt and painful turn: 'but you have cast off and abhorred, you have been full of wrath against your anointed.' The covenant appears, from the psalmist's present vantage point, to have been renounced—the crown profaned, hedges broken down, strongholds ruined, the throne cast to the ground, and the king's days of youth cut short in shame.

Verse 46-48

Raw lament follows directly: how long, Lord, will you hide yourself, will your wrath burn like fire? The psalmist appeals to the shortness of human life itself—what man lives and does not see death—as grounds for urgency.

Verse 49-52

The final appeal recalls God's own former mercies sworn to David, asks Him to remember the reproach borne by His servants and His anointed, and closes—despite everything unresolved—with a doxology: 'Blessed be the Lord for evermore. Amen, and Amen,' marking the end of Book III of the Psalter.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

This psalm holds together, without artificially resolving the tension, both confident celebration of God's unbreakable covenant promises and raw complaint that present reality seems to directly contradict them. Its unresolved ending—closing in praise despite an apparently broken covenant—points forward to a resolution the psalm itself cannot supply: the covenant's ultimate fulfillment in Christ, the true and everlasting Son of David, in whom God's promise proves faithful after all.

Application for life today.

When a specific promise of God feels, from where you stand, to have failed or been broken, let this psalm give you permission to name that tension honestly rather than either denying the pain or abandoning the promise. Notice that the psalm ends in doxology even without resolution—consider whether you can do the same, trusting God's character even when His timeline is not yet clear. Let the New Testament's identification of Christ as the true heir of this covenant anchor your hope when a promise still feels unfulfilled.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What promise of God currently feels, as in verses 38–45, like it has been broken or contradicted by your circumstances?

2. How does the psalm's move from confident praise (vv. 1–37) to raw complaint (vv. 38–51), without forcing a resolution, model something you need permission to do in your own prayer?

3. How does seeing Christ as the ultimate fulfillment of the Davidic covenant reshape your confidence when a specific promise still feels unfulfilled?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).